

The relative minor

The relative minor is the minor key that is most closely related to a given major key—called the relative major.

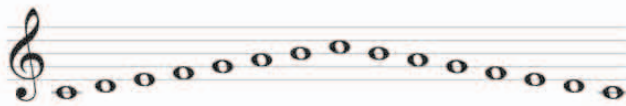
The relative minor shares a key signature with its relative major key.

SEE ALSO

◀ 60–61	Major scales
◀ 62–63	Minor scales
◀ 64–67	Keys
The circle of fifths	70–71 ▶
Harmony	118–119 ▶

What is the relative minor?

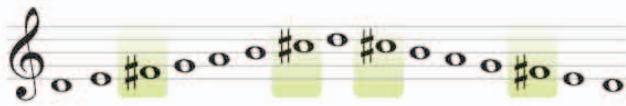
The relationship between the relative major and relative minor can be seen by looking at the notes that their major and natural minor scales use. A natural minor scale is the relative minor to the major scale that uses exactly the same sharps and flats. Shown here are some major scales and their relative natural minor scales.



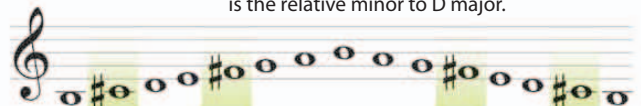
C major



A natural minor



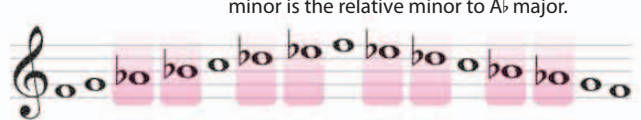
D major



B natural minor



A♭ major



F natural minor

▽ No sharps or flats

Both C major and A natural minor scales have no sharps or flats, so A minor is the relative minor to C major.

▽ Two sharps

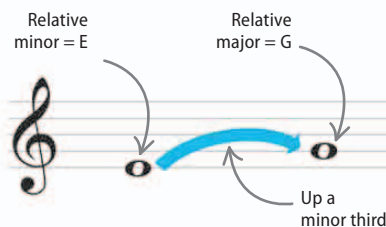
Both D major and B natural minor scales have two sharps—F# and C#—so B minor is the relative minor to D major.

▽ Four flats

Both A♭ major and F natural minor scales have four flats—B♭, A♭, E♭, and D♭—so F minor is the relative minor to A♭ major.

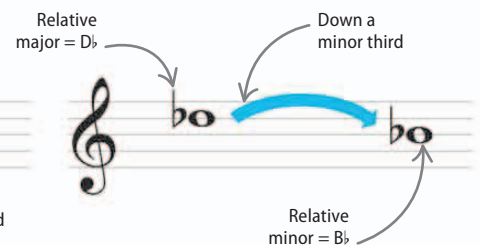
Relative major and relative minor

The starting note of a relative minor scale is a minor third below the starting note of its corresponding relative major scale. This means that the keynote of the relative minor is a minor third below the keynote of the relative major.



△ Relative major

G is a minor third above E, so G major is the relative major to E minor.



△ Relative minor

B♭ is a minor third below D♭, so B♭ minor is the relative minor to D♭ major.